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Reviewed work(s):

Source: *American Journal of Sociology*, Vol. 78, No. 3 (Nov., 1972), pp. 491-512

Published by: [The University of Chicago Press](#)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/2776304>

Accessed: 13/12/2012 01:03

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Toward the Sociology of Esoteric Culture¹

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The point of departure of this paper is an examination of the sociological literature on the recent occult revival in modern societies. This phenomenon, which clashes with the image of secularization, is particularly notable among the youth of the counterculture. To further sociological analysis, a conceptualization of esoteric culture is proposed. It is further argued that esoteric culture has played a significant role in Western cultural change, in such areas as artistic expressions of reality, political ideas, and even scientific thought. Esoteric culture is thus treated as a source of ideational innovations in Western modernization.

Among other bewildering aspects of the kaleidoscopic cultural scene of Western societies in recent years is a complex of phenomena which, for lack of a more precise label, has generally come to be designated as the "occult revival." Receiving public exposure in this context have been a variety of forms of popular entertainment dealing with occult themes, for example, the musical *Hair* with its "Age of Aquarius" hit song, movies such as *Rosemary's Baby* and *The Mephisto Waltz*, and the television series "Bewitched." Clairvoyants such as Jeanne Dixon in the United States and Madame Soleil in France have become public figures and authors of best sellers, while self-designated practitioners of witchcraft or even devil worship (as in the respective cases of Sybil Leek and Anton LaVey) have gotten public exposure in the mass media, along with attention to the macabre Tate-Manson affair and other cases of purported ritual homicides and suicides in which figured weird occult themes. Bookstores specializing in occult works of various kinds, frequently located in proximity to college campuses, are flourishing; sales of items bearing a Zodiac sign are booming and have even received in France, since 1969, a quasi-official blessing in the form of a special monthly drawing of the National Lottery. Tottering ivory towers have been no refuge from the occult revival: seminars and courses, with or without credit, have taken up the new "in" study, with the logical extreme being the recent formation of an "Aquarian University" in Maryland, offering a full range of esoteric studies from alchemy to Zen Buddhism.

¹ Revision of a paper presented at the 1971 meetings of the American Sociological Association. I wish to thank Josefina Tiryakian for assistance in the preparation of the manuscript.

The sociological response to this new cultural development is just beginning to emerge. One of the aims of this paper is to see what sociological interpretations of this phenomenon have been recently advanced. At the same time, we will seek to carry the discussion further by outlining how the present occult revival poses broader considerations for sociological inquiry, regardless of whether the revival is destined to be a short-term affair of no significance or one with more durability. What we shall seek to develop in these pages, then, is an initial formulation of the sociology of esoteric culture and its relation to the larger social context.

THE SOCIOLOGY OF THE OCCULT REVIVAL

One of the earliest and most extensive sociological treatments of the occult revival is that of Marcello Truzzi (1970), providing, in particular, much information on the spread and organization of witchcraft in contemporary urban American society. The perspective within which the materials are presented is that of the sociology of popular culture, with modern occultism taking on the significance of a "pop religion" (we might even say of coven adepts, "Have broomstick, will travel!"), which Truzzi regards as a "demystification process of what were once fearful and threatening cultural elements." Persons playing the role of witches, for example, are attacking some of the last cultural frontiers of Western psychic inhibitions; to engage in role taking of parts formerly publicly branded as odious and the object of extreme social repression is, in a sense, to demonstrate the final liberation of Western man (and woman) from traditional cultural prohibitions dealing with the supernatural. The occult revival, at least in terms of the receptivity of witchcraft among segments of the middle class, could thus be seen as another step in the modernization of Western society, in this context as a secularization of the demonic. Such a perspective would be consonant with the secularization hypothesis concerning the relation of religion to modern society (Wilson 1966).²

Supplementing Truzzi's linking of witchcraft to popular and mass culture, Marty (1970) has examined a variety of publications dealing with astrology and psychic phenomena, on the basis of which he differentiates an occult establishment, responsible for most of the widely circulated publications in this area, from an occult underground press. Marty gives most of his attention to the former and notes that it is predominantly intended for an audience of middle America. In this literature there is an absence of a social message, so that "like some forms of conservative orthodoxy, the occult establishment concentrates almost entirely on individual life and often on 'other-worldly concerns'" (Marty 1970, p. 228).

² For a recent treatment of the secularization thesis, see Robertson (1971).

Evaluations contrasting with the above have been entertained by Staude (1970) and Greeley (1970*a*, 1970*b*). Staude views the current interest of youth in occult practices and mysticism as essentially a search for meaning and identity because "they feel alienated and disillusioned with the liberal progressivist ideology of their parents and with totalistic ideologies" (1970, p. 13); in this respect, he suggests, today's cultural setting is similar to the religious and cultural renewal of the Renaissance. More directly than Staude, Greeley has seen the import of current youth interest in occult behavior in its implications for the sociology of religion. Whereas Marty (1970, p. 228) had pointed to an absence of a communal impulse in the literature of the occult establishment, Greeley stresses such an impulse in the broad neosacral movement of today: "The young people who are involved do . . . assert that their sacred, or mystical, or occult interests do indeed provide them with meaning, with community, with a contact with the transcendent, and with norms by which to live" (1970*a*, p. 6).

Greeley, like Staude, sees the appeal of occult behavior on the college campus as symptomatic of the alienation of youth from the scientific-rationalist ethos of modern society, with the invocation of new gods: superstition, ecstasy, and "groupism" (Greeley 1970*b*).³ He notes an affinity between those engaged in occult practices on the campus and the new left, not only in terms of the rejection of the dominant institutional ethos but also in terms of certain value orientations: the affirmation of the inherent goodness of human nature (an echo of both Rousseau and the much older Pelagian heresy) and the concern for transcendent power in human interaction (1970*b*, p. 208). Further characteristics of the new faiths, he suggests, are that they are millennialistic, charismatic, and liturgical. The thrust of Greeley's argument is that the occult revival is to be seen as a neosacral movement in contemporary culture, which by the significance of its presence is further evidence against the proposition that increasing secularization accompanies or is an integral aspect of modernization.⁴

Greeley's writings on the significance of occult behavior among youth, as well as his earlier empirical research (1968), constitute a major critique of the secularization hypothesis.⁵ Additional testimony in the occult

³ A justification for Greeley's terms "tribal Gods" and "tribal consciousness" is the self-designation of some communes as "tribes."

⁴ The late Howard Becker had developed, in an unfortunately neglected communication to the American Sociological Association (1960), a theoretical critique of the secularization model. Becker would have no difficulty in perceiving today's occult revival and the neoevangelical movement as instances of "normative reactions to normlessness."

⁵ Like Greeley, I see this hypothesis as having been derived from a short-sighted reading of Durkheim and Weber on the modernization process—or else as a correct reading of the mistaken notions of Spencer.

revival literature comes from a recent article of Shepherd (1972), who observes "a new mysticism emerging among the young in the developed countries, one not constrained by an already well-defined religious context" (p. 8). Arguing that the new religious life-style is analogous to the aesthetic experience of music—a theme which echoes the contention of Roszak (1969) that today's dissenting youth have returned to the archaic aesthetic vision of beauty of the shaman, a vision communally shared—Shepherd (1972) proposes that "the counter cultural young among Westerners . . . may be the agents in a process of 'reorientalization' occurring within our own culture, and that they may be the harbinger of spring, of a new value consensus" (p. 8).

In this vein, one might argue that a function of occult practices is to provide a position against what is perceived as "Establishment" mentality with its structural apparatus of modern societies: The oppressive "technocracy," "reductive rationality," and "objective consciousness," to borrow terms from Roszak. Occult practices are appealing, among other reasons, because they are seemingly dramatic opposites of empirical practices of science and of the depersonalization of the industrial order. The appeal of the occult may thus be related to the new appeal of artisan work to many college youth, since it is nonindustrial work, affording a reintegration of personality with the product of one's labor.⁶

One last sociological study of the occult in modern society to be noted here is a recent French collaborative work on contemporary astrology (Defrance et al. 1971). It is not easy to present in a few words the contents of this work which, taken as a whole, is a sociology of astrology, but several of the themes discussed earlier are elaborated here. Edgar Morin (Defrance et al. 1971, pp. 110–25) sees the appeal of astrology among youth today as stemming from the cultural crisis of bourgeois society, with astrology offering symbols of identity as a science of subjectivity. Paradoxically, modern astrology has an antithetical function in modern society: in mass culture, the popularization of astrology in the mass media plays an integrative role in bourgeois civilization by reconciling individuals with their situation. Morin suggests that among counterculture youth astrology is also part of a new gnosis which has a revolutionary conception of a new age, the Age of Aquarius.

In his chapter "Astrology and Society," Fischler (Defrance et al. 1971, pp. 69–81) considers other latent functions of astrology. Modern society multiplies fragmentary contacts between strangers, without traditional norms to guide comportment; in the face of making an increased number of decisions, especially of an interpersonal kind, resort to astrology and

⁶It is tempting to think that both artisan labor and occult work among today's college-trained youth may indicate a new nonindustrial form of inner-directed achievement orientation.

other means of divination reduces the ambiguity of intersubjective conduct. Since astrology is subject oriented, it is a means for self-apprehension and self-grasping. Fischler also presents data initially gathered in 1963 by the French Institute of Public Opinion, which examined in a cross section of the French public just how widely diffused is adherence to astrology. The survey sought the social distribution of those respondents possessing three attributes, namely, they (a) knew their own Zodiac sign, (b) read their horoscopes fairly often, and (c) thought there was some truth to astrological character traits. The results are shown in table 1.

TABLE 1
SOCIAL CHARACTERISTICS OF BELIEVERS IN ASTROLOGY (FRANCE)

Category	Percentage in Total Sample
Total believing in astrology	30
By sex:	
Men	21
Women	39
By occupation:*	
Professional, managers, and executives	34
Small business owners and artisans ("commerçants")	36
Clerical and sales ("employés")	46
Manual workers ("ouvriers")	29
Farmers and farm workers	15
Not in the labor force or retired	30
By locality:	
Under 2,000 inhabitants	21
2,000–5,000	27
5,000–20,000	37
20,000–100,000	34
Over 100,000	40
By age (years):	
20–34	38
35–49	33
50–64	24
65 and over	20

SOURCE.—Defrance et al., *Le retour des astrologues*, p. 74, from survey data gathered in 1963 by the Institut Français d'Opinion Publique, at the request of *France-Soir*.
* Since occupational classification in France differs in some cases from that commonly used in the United States, we have given in parentheses the French category in those instances where the translation is approximate.

Noting the high incidence of astrological adherence among women and those under 35, Fischler suggests (Defrance et al. 1971, pp. 80 f.) that as these formerly segregated strata enter more and more in the modern *polis*, having been less stamped by the belief systems of the dominant culture, they are more prone to recourse to astrology in relating to the larger society.

What is of further interest are additional data presented by Fischler (Defrance et al. 1971, p. 75) indicating the social distribution of two groups: (a) those having consulted at least once a card reader, a clairvoyant, or a person predicting the future; and (b) those having consulted at least once an astrologer. On the whole ($N = 6,000$ in the national sample), the results were consistent with the first survey (the more populated the community, the higher incidence in each group, etc.), save that the category of those 18–25 years of age had a lower incidence (9% and 1.5%, respectively, in the two groups) than the other age categories (which all had practically the same incidence, about 13% and 3%). Although Fischler sees in this that older persons go in for more applied astrology and the young for a more speculative curiosity, it may also be the case that the young are their own practitioners of astrology (and other divinatory practices), for whom going to professional practitioners (part of the occult establishment) would defeat the purpose of a personal quest for meaning and certainty in an ambiguous world.

Although more suggestive than conclusive, the French data point to a redrawing of a certain sociological image of superstition/rationality as distributed in society. For the greatest spread of adherence to astrology is not to be found in the countryside among farmers or among the lower rungs of the occupational structure, but rather in the most densely populated urban centers and among white-collar workers. Moreover, although the French materials are silent on this, my own observations suggest that there is a higher incidence of belief and interest not only in astrology but also in other occult sciences among those of high educational achievement—college and university level—than among those who have not gone beyond high school or those who are still in high school. Obviously, this is a terrain for further empirical studies.

In examining various sociological writings dealing with the occult revival, a number of themes have been touched upon. Most significant, perhaps, is that this phenomenon has to be seen in terms of a broader social context of cultural change. As a spiritual reaction against the rationalistic-industrial-bureaucratic ethos of modern society, it is part of the counterculture. Similarly, it may also be seen as part of a new religious cultural revitalization, having an affinity with both the exuberant neoevangelical movement crossing denominational lines and the equally vigorous political movement of the new left in developed societies.

To take the sociological interpretation of the occult in modern society further along, there is need to develop a more articulated conceptualization. For one thing, we need to differentiate basic elements of the occult, and for another, to reexamine how the occult relates to modernization in its cultural aspect. This will be undertaken in the following section.

COMPONENTS OF ESOTERIC CULTURE

The previously discussed sociological literature on the occult revival has related it, on the one hand, to the sociology of mass society, and on the other, to the sociology of religion. Since we posit that the sociology of the occult is also germane to the study of cultural change and the dynamics of modernization, it may be located more broadly as part of the sociology of culture. It is at this point that I wish to explicate some basic terms of central importance to this essay: "occult," "esoteric," and "secret society." These are familiar terms, yet ones which have had little currency in standard sociological reference works.⁷ It is necessary, before conceptualizing these terms, to have a preliminary understanding of "culture." The sense of culture which is followed here is, so to speak, that of a collective paradigm which provides the basic interpretations and justification of ongoing social existence. As the anthropologist Ward Goodenough has expressed it: "Culture then consists of the 'concepts' and 'models' which people have in their minds for organizing and interpreting their experiences." It should be noted that Goodenough takes into account non-linguistic aspects of culture (which have a bearing on the significance of symbols in esoteric culture, since symbols and imagery are primary modes of relating to reality for the latter) when he adds: "nonlinguistic forms have systematic relationships to each other in paradigms" (quoted in Singer 1968, p. 538).

Equally pertinent here is the conceptualization of Parsons viewing culture as that integral component of systems of social action which provides the fundamental symbolic grounds of expression to the existential problem of meaning inherent in social existence. Although "meaning" has a cognitive and rational orientation, it also has a complex moral one as well, one involved in the evaluation of social action. As Parsons states: "The highest level of the problem of meaning is that of the conceptions of ultimate reality, in the religio-philosophical sense. This concerns the major premises in which the nonempirical components of a culture's total belief system are rooted" (1961, p. 970).

⁷ In the sociological literature on the occult revival, I have found commonly known instances of the occult (astrology, witchcraft, etc.) but no analytical definitions or conceptual classificatory scheme subsumed under this rubric. The *International Encyclopedia of the Social Sciences* has no entry for "esoteric" or "occult" and only passing mentions of "secret societies" in a few substantive articles. The UNESCO-sponsored *A Dictionary of the Social Sciences* does have the following comment (by Kenneth Little, an anthropologist) under "Secret Society": "It is difficult [in this context] to discuss the nature of modern institutions, such as Freemasonry, but in primitive cultures secret societies generally constitute an integral part of the social system concerned" (in Gould and Kolb 1964, p. 624). Why the difficulty is not made clear.

There is one qualification that needs to be introduced to the above conceptualization of culture, since it has a crucial bearing on the central thesis of this paper. It is that a given social complex, as in the case of modern Western society, may have more than one set of major premises present in its cultural matrix; that is, that there are several cultural paradigms offering the ground of meaning of social action, albeit one set may have dominance in the institutional fabric of society while another set remains covert or latent.⁸ The cultural paradigm which is manifest in public institutions, a set of cognitive and evaluative orientations publicly recognized and legitimated in the network of social institutions, is what I propose to call "exoteric culture." Exoteric culture provides the ground of meaning and orientation for the everyday social world. It is the social basis of what the phenomenologist Husserl designated as "the natural attitude," in terms of which actors take the existence of the world for granted, that is, in a sociological sense they take as nonproblematic the institutionalized structures of the social world. It is implicitly in reference to exoteric culture that sociologists and anthropologists, for the most part, have formulated their conceptualizations regarding culture and society.

I wish to propose that a unitary conceptualization of the cultural system of Western civilization in its historical development via modernization has to be modified, and that to arrive at a more sophisticated understanding of cultural systems and societal change there is need to consider what, for heuristic purpose if nothing else, I will call "esoteric culture." It is at this juncture that we need to specify three major components of this esoteric culture, elements common to any cultural whole but taking specific forms in esoteric culture: a set of beliefs and doctrines (cognitive and moral orientations), a set of practices oriented to empirical action, and a social organization within which action is patterned or structured.

Although "esoterism" and "occultism" are often used interchangeably, and although there is no standard agreement as to their referents, it may still be fruitful to venture an analytical differentiation. Both, of course, refer to something which is not immediately given to the senses or to perception, to the nonempirical in this sense.

By "occult" I understand intentional practices, techniques, or procedures which (a) draw upon hidden or concealed forces in nature or the cosmos that cannot be measured or recognized by the instruments of modern science, and (b) which have as their desired or intended consequences empirical results, such as either obtaining knowledge of the empirical course of events or altering them from what they would have been without this intervention. Obviously, I exclude for the purpose of my analysis some

⁸ The conceptualization and research of Florence Kluckhohn (1950, 1961) on dominant and substitute value orientations is highly relevant here.

broader considerations of occult phenomena, such as extrasensory perception and *déjà vu* experiences, because these are harder to integrate within a sociological scheme. To go on further, insofar as the subject of occult activity is not just any actor, but one who has acquired specialized knowledge and skills necessary for the practices in question, and insofar as these skills are learned and transmitted in socially (but not publicly available) organized, routinized, and ritualized fashion, we can speak of these practices as occult sciences or occult arts.⁹

Commonly recognized occult practices include a variety of phenomena, such as those designated as “magic”¹⁰ and divinatory practices,¹¹ which are very numerous cross-culturally (astrology, the Tarot, and the I Ching having been particularly noted in the contemporary occult revival); they also include practices which are oriented to changing the physical nature of nonhuman objects by the active participation or ego involvement of the subject, as in the case of alchemy.

By “esoteric” I refer to those religiophilosophic belief systems which underlie occult techniques and practices; that is, it refers to the more comprehensive cognitive mappings of nature and the cosmos, the epistemological and ontological reflections of ultimate reality, which mappings constitute a stock of knowledge that provides the ground for occult procedures. By way of analogy, esoteric knowledge is to occult practices as the corpus of theoretical physics is to engineering applications. But a crucial aspect of esoteric knowledge is that it is a secret knowledge of the reality of things, of hidden truths, handed down, frequently orally and not all at once, to a relatively small number of persons who are typically ritually initiated by those already holding this knowledge. Moreover, it should be added, this knowledge is not of a detached or objective sort about an outer reality which stands against the observer as this page stands against the reader; esoteric knowledge is of a participatory sort, namely a knowledge (or gnosis) of the meaning of the world to human existence, in the progressive realization of which the subject develops internally and liberates himself from the strictures of everyday life.

Since esoteric knowledge is taken as knowledge of the real but concealed nature of things, of ultimate reality (a knowledge which therefore is divine, theosophic in the generic sense), it is important that its recipient

⁹ It is worth noting that occultism has both a scientific and an aesthetic aspect, which relates back to our earlier remarks on the meaning of the occult revival for youth. We need not dwell on how much of scientific creativity has a pronounced aesthetic dimension, and conversely.

¹⁰ Parlor tricks or stage magic is not meant here, but rather such practices as sorcery, witchcraft, ritual or ceremonial magic, and the like.

¹¹ For a succinct anthropological statement on divination, see Victor Turner (Sills 1968, 13: 440).

be demonstrated worthy of receiving it; that is he must meet criteria of acceptance into the inner circle of true knowers. Hence the need of the candidate to submit at various stages to a series of trials and ordeals, in the course of which the adept becomes increasingly socialized into the esoteric culture and increasingly desocialized from the natural attitude of the exoteric culture.¹²

At the heart of esoteric knowledge is its concealment from public dissemination, from the gaze of the profane or uninitiated. To shield it from vulgarization, it is presented to the adept not directly but, typically, symbolically or metaphorically, so that it has to be deciphered progressively by the neophyte who uncovers layers of meaning in stages of initiation. As a correlate of this, the social organization and handling of esoteric culture tends to take the form of secret societies, societies whose modes and codes of organization and membership lists are not publicly disclosed and which may even be incompletely known to members who have not attained the highest stages of initiation and spiritual perfection.

The sociology of secrecy and secret societies, which is essential for any consideration of esoteric culture, has largely lain fallow since the seminal essay by Georg Simmel (1905). Yet secrecy is of general sociological interest since, as Simmel was quick to note, it is constitutive of social structure and social interaction. Even the most democratic countries, de jure or de facto, organize much of their affairs secretly and have agencies which specialize in concealed activities; all information about the doings of formal organization is not for public consumption but only to qualified insiders, some more than others. This leads to other outsiders seeking to obtain this information in specialized ways (private and governmental espionage activity seeking industrial, military, and state secrets), with such information-gathering activities being themselves secret.

To be sure, not all secret societies pertain to esoteric culture, nor are all social organizations that have secrets, secret societies. But those secret societies which are social forms of esoteric culture have common features. They typically have rituals of initiation and are hierarchically structured in terms of strata which correspond to different degrees of initiation. Leadership and authority are functions of stages of acquisition of esoteric knowledge, at least in theory. At the top echelon is a very small elite designated variously as "Magi," "Grand Masters," or other appropriate terms, and a council responsible for ultimate internal and external policies of the

¹² The academic world may be seen, through one perspective, as routinizing and secularizing the esoteric acquisition of gnosis. At lower levels, students progress through neophyte levels known as grades. At higher levels we have *rites de passage* (qualifiers, Ph.D. orals, and the like) as we initiate students into higher stages of the academic fraternity. The Phi Beta Kappa ceremony is a symbolic accolade of those who have shown particular aptitude for academic mysteries, albeit few of its recipients may be aware of its esoteric background.

organization. The council is somewhat along the lines of an executive committee of formal organizations; an enlarged board of directors may include, as notably in the case of Freemasonry, persons holding high ranks in exoteric society, even including heads of state.¹³ Although the hierarchic principle of organization is basic to secret societies, the higher rungs are accessible to all. Moreover, fraternal solidarity is greatly emphasized: irrespective of social standing in the larger society, all members are brothers (or sisters), and when in a situation of distress, a member is to be given every assistance possible by any other member at hand, even on the battlefield, if they belong to opposite forces.

These, then, are major components of esoteric culture. It would go beyond this essay to articulate specific esoteric belief systems or to discuss the details of organization of specific secret societies. More relevant is to indicate that esoteric culture is not concretely disjoint from exoteric culture, that it coexists, albeit unobtrusively with the latter,¹⁴ or stated differently, that there are many interchanges between them.

The esoteric culture often uses as referents publicly known cultural materials such as religious texts and figures (e.g., the Torah, the Book of Revelations, Adam, Christ, etc.), but it considers that the meaning of these is not exhausted by their public definition and recognition; rather, the esoteric group sees itself as the true repository of the ultimate reality manifest in the materials in question. Only a select few, initiated into the mysteries can decipher and pass on in an unbroken chain the real meaning of what underlies the figurative. Only a few, thus, can be permitted to attain knowledge of the secret name of God which Moses learned on Mount Sinai and which has been transmitted orally to those who can correctly understand the Kabbalah; only a few can learn the secret teachings of Christ to His chosen disciples, etc.

Since these secrets are those that reveal the ultimate nature of reality, the concealed forces of the cosmic order, it means that esoteric knowledge is an ultimate source of power, which must be shared and utilized by a relatively small group of initiates. Such power is never justifiable in terms of the enhancement of the material conditions of the esoteric knowers but rather in terms of broad impersonal ends, humanitarian ideals, etc. Consequently, much of the parlance of esoteric culture is necessarily

¹³ This is institutionalized in Sweden and Great Britain where the monarch or a member of the ruling family, respectively, is the titular head of Masonry in his country; though not institutionalized in the United States, most presidents have been 33° Masons or of high rank.

¹⁴ The cultural traditions of all the major complexes of civilization and high religions have an esoteric side. Thus, Islam, Christianity, Hinduism, and Judaism have their esoteric components in Sulfism, theosophy (in various forms: Illuminism, Rose Croix, and more modern versions such as those of Blavatsky, Gurdjieff, R. Steiner), Tantric Yoga, the Kabbalah, etc.

obscure, that is, designed to put off members of the larger society; this is in some ways similar to the argot of the underworld or even to the language of some psychotics used as a shield from public deciphering. Exoteric language glosses over the esoteric source of such expressions as “third degree” (from Masonic initiation), “magnum opus” (from alchemy), or “sub rosa” (from Rose Croix), just as other items originating in the esoteric culture have been absorbed, for example, card games (the major suits trace back to the Tarot, the esoteric depiction of human existence seen as a dialectical process).

ESOTERIC CULTURE AND SOCIOCULTURAL CHANGE

It is the relation of esoteric culture to various facets of Western modernization that is of particular interest to this article. We wish to argue that much of what is modern, even the ideology of modernization at its source, has originated in esoteric culture; paradoxically, the value orientation of Western exoteric society, embodied in rationalism, the scientific ethos, and industrialism, has forced esoteric culture into the role of a marginal or underground movement. That is, modern Western civilization (dating it back to the Renaissance and Reformation) has increasingly given to esoteric culture the mantle of a counterculture, while at the same time co-opting many of its values and products.

I would like to suggest that the conceptions of ultimate reality in the esoteric tradition may be conceptualized as part of the latency subsystem of Western society, following Parsons's model of structural differentiation of social systems of action (Parsons 1969). Further, we contend that in the Western case, at least, (*a*) such esoteric conceptions and modes of interpreting reality form a cultural paradigm which provides leverage against the institutionalized paradigm, hence function as a seat of inspiration for new systems of social action; and (*b*) that at various historical points these conceptions and modes have come into play in the larger society so as to provide vehicles of social and cultural change.

Moreover, albeit to document this point would require much more space than here available, the basic cognitive model of hidden, underlying reality central to esoteric thought, is that of a reality moved by forces, by energies constantly in motion and in tension with one another; it is a model opposed to the static, stable, or harmonious view of things inherent in the natural attitude. Hence, we suggest, at the very heart of the ideology of modernization, or modernism, is an esoteric influence. This ideology, which positively evaluates what is new as against what is old, which sees the unfolding present as a time of liberation and freedom from the yoke of the stagnating past, is an ideology of a new order of things to come and of a this-worldly salvation by human means—an ideology which at least one

author (Voegelin 1952, p. 133) has seen as a product of esoteric (gnostic in this instance) symbolism manifested in the development of the Puritan Revolution.

Of relevance here is to discuss the relation between esoteric culture and avant-garde culture, for the esoteric apprehensions, depictions, and interpretations of reality find a ready-made terrain of expression in artistic products (literature, painting, architecture, even music) whose esoteric significance escapes the larger public. To the initiates such symbols are more than artistic: they also convey a message, and hence are expressive symbols in the fullest sense.

In a recent article pointing out the antithetical relation of the social structures of industrial-technological society and modern culture, Daniel Bell (1970) has noted in the latter the prevalence of a dominant impulse "towards the new and the original . . . so that the *idea* of change and novelty overshadows the dimensions of actual change" (1970, p. 17). This ideology of change, of modernism per se, is one which Bell locates in the cultural tradition of avant-garde art that appeared in the 19th century as a counterculture to the rising bourgeois culture of industrial society.¹⁵

Bell does not examine any linkage of occultism and the formation of avant-garde in the 19th century, although he proposes in passing (1970, p. 34) that what avant-garde values stand for—antistructure, antihistory, radical freedom, in brief, values of nihilism and anarchism—are part of an older Western tradition, that of gnostic esotericism.¹⁶

In a complementary article, Vytautas Kavolis has explored recently (1970) the sociopsychological nexus between avant-garde culture and what he calls "Satanic" and "Promethean" personality modes, the former characterized by a "resentment-destruction mechanism," the latter by a "sympathetic concern for the needs of others."¹⁷ These personality orientations are manifested in the activist and nihilistic aspects of avant-garde culture, oriented to both the destruction of the established order of things and to a perpetual innovation and renovation of forms. Moreover, Kavolis sees avant-garde culture as giving positive value to the symbols of the

¹⁵ For a fuller discussion of the rise and characteristics of avant-garde literary culture, see Irving Howe's essay, "The Idea of the Modern" (Howe 1967, pp. 11–40).

¹⁶ In a similar vein, Edgar Morin has spoken of the revival of astrology today as a manifestation of a new gnosis (Defrance et al. 1971, p. 123). See also the remarks of Hans Jonas (1963) on gnostic features of some modern political tendencies, including the theme of alienation.

¹⁷ Students of astrological traits might note with amusement the congruence of the Promethean and the satanic with the two sides of the Aquarian-born (today's *enfants du siècle*): "A negative Aquarian is one who . . . demands licence under the guise of liberty, and shouts for public service while serving none but himself. The positive Aquarian is . . . the humanitarian, seeking liberty not for self, but for others, dealing in the larger affairs of the country or planet, ever urging humanity upward and onward, and running ahead to show the way" (Keane 1967, p. 34).

satanic psychological mode of orientation, symbols treated as the epitome of antisocial values in the established order of society: "To some extent, the avant-garde culture could be interpreted as an attempt to legitimate much of what used to be illegitimized in the Satanic mythology" (1970, p. 27).

The influence of occult themes, particularly those dealing with the demonic and the satanic, is a striking aspect in the historical development of modern avant-garde culture, which is viewed here as both a literary and a political protest against the institutionalization of a rationalistic-industrial bourgeois social order. This protest against modernization was a major common denominator in the Romantic movement, and esoteric culture provided much of the materials for the protest against the new social order, though neither esoteric culture nor avant-garde culture sought a return to the *ancien régime*. Ritual magic, "forces of darkness," Satan himself, became symbols of identification, rallying points, in brief, revolutionary forces drawn from the counterculture of the occult,¹⁸ in the fight against bourgeois values. The occult as a source of inspiration abounds, then, in writings of well-known and lesser-known Romantics, such as Goethe (Lepinte 1957), Novalis, Gautier, Nerval, Byron, Lautréamont, and Baudelaire (Bays 1964).¹⁹

Such themes of the occult were continued by later generations of the avant-garde culture,²⁰ notably the "accursed" symbolist poets such as Rimbaud and Verlaine (Senior 1959), but also Yeats and Thomas Mann, and finally, André Breton, the crucial figure of surrealism, a movement of particular sociological significance since it represents a clear articulation of artistic protest and political radicalism.²¹ Many of the surrealists (Breton himself, Aragon, Eluard, Naville) were or are politically committed to the radical left, and the influence of surrealism is even to be

¹⁸ For a fuller statement on the social significance of Satan in the last century, see the cogent remarks of Eugen Weber (1964).

¹⁹ Note here the observation of Howe (1967) in commenting upon a passage of Baudelaire: "[This seems] the report of a desire to create . . . the very ground of being, through a permanent revolution of sensibility and style, by means of which art could raise itself to the level of white or (more likely) black magic" (p. 17).

²⁰ To do full justice to the role of esoteric culture as an inspirational source for avant-garde culture, one should also examine esoteric influences on earlier literary and artistic innovators, such as Shakespeare (Arnold 1965; Reed 1965) and Rabelais (Masters 1969), to say nothing about esoteric currents in painting and architecture (Van Lennep 1966).

²¹ In commenting on "Surrealism and Revolution," Camus stated: "The essential enemy of Surrealism is rationalism. Breton's method . . . presents the peculiar spectacle of a form of Occidental thought in which the principle of analogy is continually favored to the detriment of the principles of identity and contradiction. . . . Magic rites, . . . alchemy . . . are so many miraculous stages on the way to unity and the philosopher's stone" (Howe 1967, p. 218).

found in the writings of A. Césaire, one of the founders of *Négritude*, the cultural arm of black liberation. Breton drew upon various sources of inspiration (including Marx, Freud, and occultism) to formulate a revolutionary consciousness aimed against the bourgeois world (of utility, reason, realism, and technological society), a consciousness whose intention “is always to allow the *irruption* of ‘wild’ images that will disturb the sensibility by shattering the coherence of those ‘stable’ images that make up, for each individual, the objective world (Willener 1970, p. 224).

The contemporary significance of surrealism as a source of inspiration for the May 1968 revolutionary movement in France has been fully discussed in an excellent sociological study by Willener (1970).²²

In the political development of modern society, both in the West and in the Westernization (including imperial domination) of the “Third World,” esoteric culture has also had an influence in avant-garde political movements and ideologies which have pitted themselves against established regimes. A major social vehicle of such protest have been secret societies: Weishaupt’s Bavarian Illuminati in the 18th century, Freemasonry in France in the 18th and 19th centuries, the Carbonari in Italy and France, Mazzini’s Young Italy, the Sinn Féin in Ireland, and many others. For the most part, the ideology of such secret societies was nationalistic, republican, anticlerical, even internationalistic. All these drew upon the imagery and expressive symbols of esoteric conceptions of reality, especially symbols of the liberation of man from the yoke of darkness (politically interpreted as the yokes of traditional political institutions or alien oppressors) into the realm of light, of freed humanity. For the most part, these movements succeeded in establishing political regimes which at least partly satisfied their aspirations.²³

Assuredly, not all secret societies drawing upon esoteric symbols, rituals, and interpretations can be classified as progressive, for there is the minority case of those having a reactionary image, such as the Ku Klux Klan in the United States, the Cagoule in the France of the 1930s, and even, in the light of the discussion provided by Pauwels and Bergier (1968), there were esoteric influences operative in secret societies (such as the Thulé order)

²² The hexing of the Pentagon and the Stock Exchange (to say nothing of an Establishment department of sociology) and the adoption of the acronym WITCH attest in their own modest way to the appeal of occult symbolism in some sectors of radical students. To my knowledge there was no manifest influence of surrealism in these instances.

²³ Thus, the very symbols of the Great Seal of the United States (the luminous delta, the pyramid) are esoteric symbols of Freemasonry, to which belonged most of the founding fathers; similarly for the symbols of the French Republic (especially that of 1848), whose motto “Liberty, Equality, Fraternity” represents cherished ideals of Masonry formulated in lodges before the French Revolution. Simón Bolívar, the liberator of South America from Spanish rule, was also imbued with Masonic ideals, as was Garibaldi in Italy, etc.

that played a covert role in the formation of nazism. This is perhaps indicative of the fact that esoteric culture, with its fantastic wealth of imagery and symbolism, is multivalent in terms of political expressions that can be derived from it. Yet, whatever the specific instance, it may be said that esoteric culture provides leverage against the existing order by grounding political reflection and action in a reality that transcends that of everyday life,²⁴ but which is a reality that may become actualized in the historical future by reversing the present order of the world.

One other aspect of the political expressions of modern counterculture to be noted is that of Marxism. Its crucial leverage against bourgeois mentality is its formulation of dialectical materialism, which provided Marx and Engels the key with which to unlock the hidden laws of the historic process. The intellectual progenitor of modern dialectics is commonly taken to be Hegel, but the recent study of Benz (1968) has demonstrated the extent to which esoteric and mystical sources figure in the German intellectual background of Hegelian and Marxist thought. Notable sources are theosophy, philosophical alchemy, and the Kabbalah, drawing much inspiration from the writings of earlier mystics such as Meister Eckhart and particularly Jacob Boehme, and reinterpreted in early 19th-century German theosophic and evangelical circles, as well as philosophical circles which also partook of the Romantic movement.²⁵

A last consideration involving the outputs of esoteric culture to the development of modern Western civilization is its relation to scientific thought. The latter in its empiricist and positivistic image of an objective reality, measurable by empirical means and existing independently of the human subject, is perhaps the key mode of thought in the modernization process which has illegitimated and devalued the practices of occult science. Yet, paradoxically, esoteric influences in the form of symbolisms, imagery, practices, and cosmologies, have been in much of the background of the rise of scientific disciplines.

In the case of modern depth psychology, Bakan (1958) has brought out

²⁴ S. N. Eisenstadt's evaluation of the ability of Chinese Communists to draw upon various threads of protest in Chinese society and wield them into a common cause is highly germane here. He signals in particular that such a linkage "enabled some gentry groups . . . some secret societies, some warlords and some peasant rebels to go beyond their own restricted social orientation and to find a wider basis and forge out new, broader orientations" (1971, pp. 49 f.). It is our contention that these orientations are likely to have originated, at least in part, in esoteric doctrines formulated in secret societies. In the case of China, of noteworthy mention in the rise of national consciousness is the case of the Taiping (Shih 1967).

²⁵ Among other things contained in the esoteric conceptions of the theologian Oetinger, a generation before Marx, are such themes as an eschatological view of history and the coming freedom of man in a "Golden Age" in which the state, private property, and a money economy will disappear in communal equality and love (Benz 1968, pp. 32-53).

various elements of the Jewish mystical tradition which frame much of Freud's psychoanalysis; the latter's theory of the libido and the significance of symbols in the psychic process (including the analogic linkage of symbols) may be seen as a scientific formulation of elements of the Kabbalah and the Zohar. His one-time heir apparent, Jung, made intensive studies of medieval and Renaissance alchemy (Jung 1968*a*, 1968*b*) which he linked to personality development. Freud was early influenced by Charcot's experiments in hypnotism, but the foundations of hypnotism had been laid nearly a century before by the occultist Mesmer's demonstrations of magnetism (Mesmer 1971).

Even in the natural sciences esoteric influences have played a not insignificant role, which can only be mentioned in passing. If today the alchemical symbols of chemical elements remain a glossed-over vestige, the development of chemistry from its matrix in late medieval alchemy deserves mention (e.g., Stillman 1960). Alchemy and astrology may also have been of importance in the rise of modern medicine, with Paracelsus being another key figure mediating between esoteric culture and modern scientific thought—the innovation of operating on human bodies may have been guided by an attempt to establish the correctness of astrological views that different parts of the body, and consequent pathologies, are under the influence of different signs of the Zodiac. Astrology and theosophy were also part of the cultural baggage which was utilized rather than rejected by modernizing scientists, such as Kepler and even Newton (Hutin 1960). The very social organization of modern science, in the form of academies of science, owes much inspiration to Francis Bacon's *New Atlantis* with its "scientists' Paradise," a work said to come out of the "Hermetic-Cabalist" stream (Yates 1964, p. 450).²⁶

So much for some indications, necessarily brief and incomplete, of the range of esoteric influences in the historical process of modernization.

CONCLUSION

Marginal as the occult revival may initially appear to sociological preoccupations, the study of the esoteric in fact touches on many facets of our discipline, such as the sociology of knowledge, the sociology of art, the sociology of religion, and the sociology of deviance.²⁷ For heuristic

²⁶ Once organized, the scientific community broke formally with esoteric culture. This was symbolized in 1666 upon the establishment of the French Academy of Sciences, membership in which excluded the practice of astrology. A few years before France had still had an official state astrologer, Morin de Villefranche, professor of mathematics at the prestigious College de France, who had sought to modernize and rationalize astrology with mathematical precision.

²⁷ In the context of the latter, see the study of differential reactions to witchcraft

purpose, this essay has mainly placed the emphasis on esoteric culture as an important promulgator of a counterculture of long standing in the West. Essentially, we have viewed the function of esoteric culture to be that of a seed-bed cultural source of change and wide-ranging innovations in art, politics, and even science, analogous to the functions of "seed-bed societies" discussed by Parsons (1966) in the case of Israel and Greece.²⁸

In discussions of social change elsewhere (Tiryakian 1967, 1970), I have proposed that important ideational components of change (i.e., changes in the social consciousness of reality) may often originate in non-institutionalized groups or sectors of society whose paradigms of reality may, in certain historical moments, become those which replace institutionalized paradigms and become in turn new social blueprints. Relating this to the present essay, I would propose that esoteric culture, and groups of actors mediating esoteric to exoteric culture, are major inspirational sources of cultural and social innovations.

To document and validate this model is obviously no easy matter. It involves demonstrating the meaningful sociohistorical affinity between seemingly heterogenous social spheres of action, a methodological problem of exactly the same nature as the one involved in Max Weber's study of the affinity of ascetic Protestantism and the ethical basis of modern capitalism. The magnitude of the problem involved in relating esoteric culture to social innovations in exoteric culture is even greater than the Protestant case. It involves developing tools of analysis which will enable us, as sociologists, to make sense out of esoteric texts and documents, many of which depend on being able to decipher the meanings of expressive symbols which are by their nature qualitative expressions of reality, and not subject to quantitative measurement in their presentation. A promising avenue here may be the techniques of linguistic and structural anthropology, for example those used in deciphering mythologies, which have similarities to esoteric conceptions of reality. The increasing applications of phenomenology (which is, after all, oriented to the inner grasping of structures of consciousness) in the social sciences (Natanson 1972), such as those being developed by ethnomethodology, may be particularly fruitful in this vein.²⁹

The problem of indicating linkages between esoteric symbolisms, imageries, and conceptions of reality to purposive social behavior, that is, the

in England and on the Continent by Currie (1968). For other materials on witchcraft, deviance, and social structure, see the New England study of Erikson (1966).

²⁸ We might note in passing that Western esoteric culture has deep historical roots in cultural aspects of both Israel and Greece, notably the prophetic and Kabbalistic traditions of the former and the rituals of the mystery cults of the latter.

²⁹ A student of Harold Garfinkel, Trent Eglin, is presently preparing an ethnomethodological study of alchemy.

question of how conceptions of the structure of reality translate into paradigms of social action and social imagery (e.g., how the esoteric notion of the androgyne, Adam Kadmon, is linked today to fashion designers of unisex clothes) is also laden with serious methodological difficulties. And this is rendered even more serious by the fact that major mediating groups between the two cultures tend to operate in socially invisible or secret social organizations, which means a paucity of readily available informative documents, or in some cases, an undue reliance on records of governmental and other institutional agencies which have sought to repress these esoteric groups.

Nonetheless, these methodological vexations should be seen as more of a challenge to the sociological imagination than in principle insoluble. The very framing of theoretical questions concerning the relation of esoteric to exoteric culture, particularly in the area of conceptualizing the dynamics of social change, may suggest new methodological developments to the sociological enterprise.

A final note on the occult revival may be apposite in reconsidering the crucial notion of the modernization process. It may be fruitful to view modernization in a broader historical context than just that of the past 200 years or so, to view it instead as stretching back to antiquity, in the course of which modern ideas have dislodged previously institutionalized paradigms during "crucial periods"³⁰ of social change—a recurrent feature in the development of Western society. The net effect has been, to venture an analogy, a stochastic process of change rather than one of continuous development, one punctuated by adaptive mutations in the cultural code of Western civilization, to propose yet another analogy.

In the historical unfolding of Western civilization, occult revivals have attended such crucial periods of transition from one cultural matrix to another. The waning period of the Roman Empire is a case at hand, with a great flourish of esoteric culture and symbols (much of which was absorbed in primitive Christianity prior to its institutionalization under Constantine). The Renaissance/Reformation period is another major one of shifting cultural paradigms, representing a rejection of the rationalism of medieval scholasticism and of established ecclesiastical authority, having consequences in a variety of social domains. It is during this period, and not the antecedent medieval period, that there was a major occult revival, with esoteric culture becoming a major vehicle of new expressive symbols and belief systems, a source of new value orientations.³¹

³⁰ I have taken this suggestive term from Balandier (1971a, p. 202) in preference to the overworked "periods of crisis." In this and other writings (1970, 1971b), Balandier has been developing a theory of modernity which seems particularly fruitful for reformulating the dynamics of change.

³¹ For an outstanding historical study of this cultural context, see Yates (1964).

In both of these instances the particular thrust of efficacy of esoteric culture lay, I would suggest, in the exoteric culture having what may be characterized as a loss of confidence in established symbols and cognitive models of reality, in the exhaustion of institutionalized collective symbols of identity, so to speak. There was what may be called a "retreat from reason into the occult" (Yates 1964, p. 449), a retreat not in the sense of a total "leaving of the field," to borrow from Kurt Lewin, but rather in the sense of a religious retreat, a temporary withdrawal for inspirational meditation which provides a restoring of psychic energy to be used in re-entering the everyday life with greater vigor.

The occult revival of today is, in this perspective, comparable with previous such phenomena, even including the contemporary attacks against institutionalized rationality, attacks which take irrational forms in the now generation. To make sense of the irrational, the modes and conditions in which it occurs, as well as possible societal consequences deriving from it, is a basic concern of the sociology of the occult. If we come to perceive the occult revival of today not as an ephemeral fad of mass society but as an integral component in the formation of a new cultural matrix, more likely international than national in scope, if we see it, in brief, as an important vehicle in the restructuring of collective representations of social reality, we will see (with or without the third eye) the Age of Aquarius as a major sociological happening.

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